

Zero to First Client — The 7-Day Plan

From Nothing to Paid AI Automation Client in One Week — by @taruns_ai

This is the exact playbook I'd follow if I had to start over from scratch today. No audience, no portfolio, no testimonials. Just a laptop and 2-3 hours per day. I used a version of this plan to build to Top Rated Plus with 100% Job Success on Upwork, land 15 staffing firm clients, and hit a \$14,840 single project. You can do the same.

Before you start: You need an Upwork account (free), a Gmail address, and access to n8n (free, open source). That's it. Everything else you'll set up along the way.

DAY 1 — UPWORK PROFILE SETUP

What to do

Build your Upwork profile from zero to "client-ready" using the Upwork Profile Template (see the PROFILE lead magnet for the fill-in-the-blank version).

1. **Headline:** Use the format: "I help [niche] [outcome] using [tool] — [proof point]."
Example: "I help staffing firms cut hiring time from 6 weeks to 1 week using n8n + AI automation."
2. **Overview (bio):** 3 paragraphs — (1) Who you help and what result you deliver. (2) How you do it (tools + method). (3) CTA to message you. Keep it under 200 words.
3. **Skills:** Add 15 skills. Mix broad (Automation, AI, Workflow Design) with specific (n8n, Make.com, API Integration, ChatGPT, Claude).
4. **Portfolio:** Skip for now — you'll build this on Day 3.
5. **Hourly rate:** Set to \$50/hr. You'll quote projects, not hourly, but this signals quality.
6. **Profile photo:** Professional headshot. Plain background, good lighting. Phone camera is fine.

Time estimate

2-3 hours

Tools needed

Upwork account, the PROFILE template PDF

What "done" looks like

Your Upwork profile is 100% complete. Headline has a specific niche + outcome. Bio mentions at least one result (even if hypothetical: "workflows like these have helped staffing firms cut hiring from 6 weeks to 1 week"). All 15 skill tags are set.

DAY 2 — BUILD YOUR FIRST N8N AUTOMATION

What to do

Build a simple but real automation: Form Submission → Email Notification → Google Sheet Log. This takes 30 minutes and becomes your first portfolio piece.

1. **Install n8n:** Run

```
npx n8n
```

or use n8n.cloud (free tier). Open the editor at localhost:5678.

2. **Add a Webhook node:** This is your "form submission" trigger. Copy the test URL — you'll use it to simulate form entries.
3. **Add a Gmail node:** Connect your Gmail. Set "To" as your own email. Subject: "New Lead: {{\$json.name}}". Body: "Name: {{\$json.name}}, Email: {{\$json.email}}, Message: {{\$json.message}}".
4. **Add a Google Sheets node:** Create a new Google Sheet called "Leads." Columns: Name, Email, Message, Date. Connect the node and map the fields.
5. **Test it:** Use the webhook test URL to send a sample JSON payload:

```
{"name": "Test Lead", "email": "test@example.com", "message": "I need help with automation"}
```

6. **Verify:** Check that (a) you received the email, (b) the row appeared in Google Sheets.

Time estimate

1-2 hours (including n8n setup)

Tools needed

n8n (free), Gmail, Google Sheets

What "done" looks like

A working 3-node automation that captures a form submission, sends you an email, and logs the lead in a spreadsheet. You've tested it end-to-end and it works.

DAY 3 — RECORD YOUR FIRST PORTFOLIO PIECE

What to do

Record a 3-minute Loom or Vidyard walkthrough of the automation you built on Day 2. This becomes your portfolio video.

1. **Install Loom or Vidyard:** Free Chrome extension. Vidyard is free forever; Loom free tier works too.
2. **Script your walkthrough (don't wing it):**

Intro (15 sec): "Here's an automation I built that captures leads from a web form, sends instant email notifications, and logs everything in Google Sheets – no code required."

Demo (2 min): Walk through the n8n workflow. Show each node. Trigger the webhook live. Show the email arriving. Show the Google Sheet updating.

Close (30 sec): "This same pattern works for appointment bookings, contact forms, survey responses – any time you need to capture data and act on it instantly. I build these for [your niche] businesses."

1. **Upload to Upwork portfolio:** Add the video link, title it "Lead Capture Automation — n8n Workflow Demo", and write a 2-sentence description.

Time estimate

1-1.5 hours (including re-takes)

Tools needed

Loom or Vidyard (free), the n8n workflow from Day 2

What "done" looks like

A clean 3-minute video is uploaded to your Upwork portfolio. It shows a real working automation with a professional walkthrough. You sound confident and clear.

DAY 4 — WRITE YOUR FIRST 5 PROPOSALS

What to do

Find 5 jobs on Upwork that match your niche and send proposals using the 4-line template.

1. **Search for jobs:** Use keywords like "automation," "n8n," "workflow," "AI integration," "make.com," or "[your niche] + automation." Filter to jobs posted in the last 24 hours with fewer than 10 proposals.
2. **Use the 4-line proposal format:**

Line 1: Specific observation about their job post (proves you read it)
Line 2: Relevant experience or result ("I built a similar workflow for a staffing firm – cut their hiring time from 6 weeks to 1 week")
Line 3: How you'd approach their project (1-2 sentences)
Line 4: Soft CTA ("Happy to share a quick Loom walkthrough of how I'd set this up. Worth a look?")

1. **Attach your portfolio video** from Day 3 to every proposal.
2. **Keep each proposal under 150 words.** Clients skim. Short wins.
3. **Send all 5.** Don't overthink. Speed beats perfection at this stage.

Time estimate

2-3 hours (including job searching)

Tools needed

Upwork account, the 4-line proposal template

What "done" looks like

5 proposals sent to real jobs. Each is personalized (Line 1 references something specific from their post). Your portfolio video is attached to every one.

DAY 5 — FOLLOW UP + SEND 5 MORE

What to do

Follow up on yesterday's proposals that haven't been viewed or responded to. Then send 5 new proposals.

1. **Check proposal status:** Go to Upwork → My Proposals → Submitted. See which have been viewed.
2. **For viewed but no reply:** Send a follow-up message on the job thread. Keep it short: "Hi [Name], wanted to add — I mapped out a quick approach for this. Happy to share it if helpful." (Don't re-pitch.)
3. **For not viewed:** No action yet. Give it 48 hours.
4. **Send 5 new proposals** using the same 4-line template. Try a slightly different niche or keyword if yesterday's jobs were thin.

Time estimate

2-3 hours

Tools needed

Upwork account

What "done" looks like

All Day 4 proposals have been followed up on (where applicable). 5 new proposals sent — that's 10 total proposals in 2 days. You're building momentum.

DAY 6 — POST YOUR FIRST LINKEDIN CONTENT

What to do

Share what you built this week on LinkedIn. This is your first piece of content — it doesn't need to be perfect, it needs to exist.

1. **Write a post using this framework:**

Hook: "I built my first AI automation this week. Here's what happened."

Body (5-7 lines):

- What you built (the form → email → sheet workflow)
- How long it took (be honest – "about 2 hours")
- What it does for a business (saves 30+ min/day of manual data entry)
- One thing you learned
- What you're building next

CTA: "If you're in [niche] and still doing [pain point] manually, DM me 'AUDIT' – I'll show you what to automate first."

1. **Add a screenshot** of your n8n workflow as the post image. Visual posts get 2-3x more reach.
2. **Post between 8-10am** on a weekday for maximum reach.
3. **Engage:** For the next 30 minutes after posting, comment on 5-10 other posts in your niche. This boosts your post's visibility.

Time estimate

1-1.5 hours (writing + engaging)

Tools needed

LinkedIn account, screenshot of your n8n workflow

What "done" looks like

One LinkedIn post is live with a screenshot. You've commented on 5-10 other posts. You've started building your presence — even if you get 0 likes, you showed up.

DAY 7 — WEEKLY REVIEW + PLAN WEEK 2

What to do

Review your first week, track your numbers, and plan next week's actions.

1. Track your Week 1 metrics:

Metric	Your Number
Proposals sent	_____ (target: 10)
Proposals viewed	_____
Replies / interviews	_____
Discovery calls booked	_____
Portfolio pieces created	_____ (target: 1)

LinkedIn posts published

_____ (target: 1)

1. **Diagnose:** If 0 replies from 10 proposals — your proposals need work, not more volume. Re-read the 4-line template. If replies but no calls — your follow-up is weak. If calls but no close — your pricing or pitch needs adjustment.

2. **Plan Week 2:**

- Send 10 more proposals (2 per day Mon-Fri)
- Build 1 more automation (pick from the n8n Workflow Templates guide)
- Record 1 more portfolio video
- Post 2-3 times on LinkedIn
- Follow up on every open proposal

1. **Set a recurring weekly review** every Sunday for 30 minutes. Same metrics, same format.

Time estimate

1 hour

Tools needed

Google Sheet or Notion for tracking, your Upwork dashboard

What "done" looks like

You have a completed Week 1 scorecard. You know exactly what worked and what didn't. Your Week 2 plan is written down with specific daily actions.

The 3 rules that got me to Top Rated Plus, 100% Job Success, and \$14,840 projects:

1. Time + Money + Effort — pick two. No money? Invest time and effort. No time? Invest money (ads, tools) and effort. There's no shortcut that eliminates all three.

2. Until \$10K/month, your only problem is lead generation. Not your skills. Not your tools. Not your pricing. You don't have enough people seeing your offer. Fix that first. Everything else is a distraction.

3. Consistency beats talent. The freelancer who sends 10 proposals every week for 3 months will always beat the one who sends 50 in week one and quits. Show up every day. The math works if you do.